

“The **fetus** is attached to the **womb** just like **fruit to a tree**, which when it proceeds from the flower is **extremely delicate**.”

TROTULA, 12TH-CENTURY ITALIAN TEXTS ON WOMEN'S MEDICINE

EXPERIENCES OF CHILDBIRTH

Hard labor

No matter how rewarding the result, throughout history childbirth has been dangerous and often unavoidable. In many communities, women worked together to ease the way for mothers bringing new lives into the world.

THE HISTORY OF LABOR often begins with a look at who was present, or absent, from the birthing room. For thousands of years, it was midwives, fellow women, who were the traditional birth partner of the laboring woman. Australian Aboriginal women traditionally left their home camp with female elders to labor in a secret place. They believed that giving birth among nature was a spiritual experience that created a bond between mother, child, and the world.

In the 19th century, Inuit tribes in northern Canada involved anyone who was present to help with the birth of a child. Older children were not shielded from birth, as this

was seen as a way for them to gain experience, and husbands might just as easily serve as midwives as the woman's mother or female relatives. In Nigeria today, many women choose to give birth in their local church, with the pastor as a birth attendant. They believe that in this sacred space, women can pray without hindrance, and their physical closeness to God will bring them a complication-free birth.

Pain relief

While sacred texts such as the Bible say that labor pains were a punishment visited on the first mother, ways to alleviate them have long been a focus for both birth attendants and

mothers themselves. In medieval Europe, women commonly wore protective amulets and special prayers were written for the laboring woman. With the invention of laudanum in the 16th century by the Swiss physician Paracelsus, and chloroform—used by Queen Victoria in 1853—Western women increasingly sought to lessen labor pains by chemical means. Other cultures had different

“A pregnant woman is in more **serious danger** than sailors and horsemen.”

CHINESE PROVERB

WOMAN IN LABOR MINIATURE 500-1500

